

Schoenberg, Adorno, and the Collapse of *Vermittlung*:

Quantifying the Erosion of Tonal Mediation through Triadic Presence

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Abstract

This paper takes Theodor W. Adorno's concept of *Vermittlung*, mediation¹, as its starting point, understood as the way coherence in art depends on historically conditioned structures whose binding force may become exhausted. For Adorno, tonality once fulfilled this role, yet by the early twentieth century the triad had come to resemble money "denounced as counterfeit" (*Philosophy of New Music*, trans. Hullot-Kentor, 2006, 179; 9). Although this comparison was not intended as a direct economic correlation, it points to a structural parallel: both money and tonality lose their binding function when the systems that sustain them break down.

Schoenberg's piano works provide a focused case study of this transformation across three Austrian contexts: the relative stability of the late Austro-Hungarian Empire (*Drei Klavierstücke* Op. 11, 1909), the inflationary crisis of the First Republic (*Suite für Klavier* Op. 25, 1921–23), and the post-stabilisation period under the schilling² (*Klavierstücke* Op. 33a, 1928, and Op. 33b, 1931). The analysis quantifies the presence of triadic structures by measuring the proportion of triads in general³ and root-position triads relative to both onset events⁴ and notehead counts. These measures provide a comparative index of the extent to which Schoenberg's writing remains connected to, or departs from, tonal reference points.

Rather than establishing causality or evaluating aesthetic value, the study traces how shifts in historical conditions are reflected in compositional materials. While not capturing the full complexity of Schoenberg's harmonic language, the results suggest that the triad does not simply disappear, but is progressively reconfigured as its structural role weakens. Placed alongside Austrian economic data from the same periods, the analysis frames these works as part of a broader historical process in which mediation falters and is transformed.

¹ Throughout this paper, "mediation" is used as the standard English translation of Adorno's term *Vermittlung*. While *Vermittlung* has a specific philosophical genealogy in German Idealism, it is not fully captured by the English term "mediation," which often suggests instrumental or technical means. In this article, mediation is therefore understood in Adorno's sense as a historically conditioned process through which relations become intelligible, binding, and socially credible, rather than as a neutral medium or tool. The German term *Vermittlung* is retained where conceptual precision or direct engagement with Adorno's terminology is required.

² The Austrian schilling was introduced in 1925 to stabilise the currency after the postwar inflation, replacing the depreciated krone.

³ "Triads in general" refers to complete triads in any inversion. Root-position triads are treated separately, since only they preserve the full hierarchical articulation through which the triad historically functioned as a mediating harmonic form. Further details on the analytical parameters and definitions employed in this classification are provided in Chapter 3.

⁴ An onset event was defined computationally as the collection of all note attacks occurring at the same global temporal position in the score.

1. Introduction

This article builds on a previous study in which Adorno's concept of *Vermittlung* and the historical role of the triad as a principle of musical coherence were examined in detail (Correia Lima da Silva, *Musical and Monetary Vermittlung: Trust, Coherence, and Adorno's Critique*, unpublished manuscript). Rather than reiterating that theoretical framework, the present contribution turns to its methodological implementation through a reproducible quantitative analysis. Tonality as a mediating structure is operationalised here in deliberately minimal terms: instead of reconstructing latent harmonic functions, the analysis concentrates on the explicit presence of triads as articulated musical events. Only triads occurring as explicitly articulated simultaneous onset structures are considered, while arpeggiated or inferential harmonies are excluded, thereby confining the investigation to directly notated harmonic configurations and translating the problem of mediation into one of structural visibility.

The juxtaposition of musical and economic data does not imply direct causality, but highlights a shared structural logic: systems of mediation depend on historically contingent conventions sustained by collective trust, and when that trust erodes, such systems persist in altered or destabilised forms rather than disappearing outright. Against this background, the changing visibility of triadic structures in Schoenberg's piano writing, *Drei Klavierstücke* Op. 11 (1909), *Suite für Klavier* Op. 25 (1921–23), and *Klavierstücke* Op. 33a (1928) and Op. 33b (1931), can be examined as part of a broader constellation in which established frameworks of coherence and equivalence are subjected to crisis. The central question guiding this study is therefore whether measurable shifts in the explicit presence of triads in Schoenberg's piano works correspond to historically distinct regimes of economic mediation. The following sections outline the historical context, describe the computational method, present the quantitative results, and return to the question of mediation in light of the findings.

2. Historical Context: Schoenberg and Austrian Monetary Transformation

By the late nineteenth century, Austria-Hungary had aligned itself with the dominant European monetary order through the adoption of the gold standard in 1892. The reform followed decades marked by suspensions of convertibility and periods of forced circulation, most notably after the crisis of 1873. Stabilisation was secured through a 60 million gulden international loan raised in German, Dutch, and Belgian markets by a syndicate led by the *Creditanstalt* and the Rothschilds. The move to gold was widely understood not merely as technical reform but as an act of symbolic alignment with monetary orthodoxy; as Schumpeter later observed, the gold standard functioned as a “symbol of sound practice and badge of honor and decency.” On the eve of the First World War, Austria thus operated within a regime of gold convertibility that provided a comparatively stable framework of monetary mediation (Kindleberger 1984, 130).

The collapse of the Habsburg Monarchy in 1918 radically altered these conditions. Vienna, once the imperial centre of a vast economic space, was especially hard hit by the disintegration of the Monarchy, as new national borders cut the city off from its economic lifelines. The war and its aftermath produced not only political rupture but profound economic dislocation. Inflation, which had begun during the war through the expansion of paper money, accelerated in the early years of the First Republic. The worthlessness of wartime savings bonds and runaway inflation left many middle-class Austrians in unprecedented economic straits, effectively eradicating the savings that